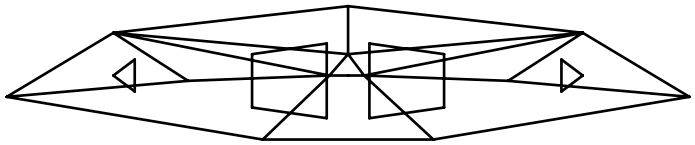

[4]

"hello, world\n"

Origin of the Phrase
in Programming

November 2nd, 2026

Controlling complexity is the essence of computer programming.
-- &Brian Wilson Kernighan

The phrase, "Hello, World", in the context of programing, is most popularly taken from a book: "The C Programming Language" by &Brian W. Kernighan and &Dennis M. Ritche. [1, pp. 9-12,37,83,87,95,126]

```
#include <stdio.h>
main()
{
    printf("hello, world\n");
}
```

It was, however, not the first occurence of the phrase being used in the context of a programing example. In relation to the authors, the first use was actually in a Bell Laboratories Computing Science Technical Report in 1973, compared to 1978. It was, however, shown in a different form [2, Ch. 23]:

```
a "hello"; b "world'*;
v[2] "now is the time", "for all good men",
    "to come to the aid of the party";
```

Specifically in 'A Tutorial Introduction to the Language B' by &Brian, which details the programming language B. In the "Jargon File" for the BCPL entry, a predicessor to B, hints of its use going back further [3]:

```
:BCPL: //, n.

... It reached break-even point at a
very  early  stage, and was the language in which the original {hello
world}  program  was written ...
```


[1] W. Kernighan and M. Ritchie, "The C Programming Language," 1st ed. 1978.[Book]

[2] W. Kernighan, "A Tutorial Introduction to the Language B." 1973. [Online]
Available: https://www.nokia.com/bell-labs/about/dennis-m-ritchie/btut.html
Accessed: Sep. 29, 2026 (wb)

[3] S. Raymond, "Jargon File." 2003. [Online]
Available: https://jargonfile.johnswitzerland.com/BCPL.html
Accessed: Sep. 10, 2025 (wb)

[4] M. Moxon, "Ship Blueprints - Elite on the 6502," bbcelite.com, 2020. [Online]
Available: https://elite.bbcelite.com/deep_dives/ship_blueprints.html
Accessed: Apr. 18, 2026 (wb)

[5] Wikipedia Contributors, "Brian Kernighan", wikipedia.org, Dec 15, 2019.[Online]
Available: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brian_Kernighan
Accessed: Nov. 02, 2026